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MEMORANDUM

TO: Local Government Unit of Bacolod, Lanao del Norte

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SUBJECT: Data-Driven Policy Recommendations for Optimizing Household Waste Segregation under RA 9003

Rationale and Background

Despite existing local and national laws, household waste segregation in Bacolod remains low, currently estimated at just 10%. Our research shows that this is not due to a lack of environmental awareness. Instead, the primary barrier is the physical hassle of washing, sorting, and storing waste at home.

Furthermore, the municipality's ₱1.5 million annual Solid Waste Management (SWM) budget is spread too thin across all barangays to effectively encourage better habits. To improve compliance, the LGU must adopt a highly targeted approach that makes segregation as easy as possible for the average household.

Key Findings

- **The "Convenience Barrier":** The primary reason people do not segregate is simply that it is physically difficult or inconvenient, which accounts for 83% of the behavioral problem. When logistical friction is high (e.g., lack of accessible bins or collection support), it overrides a person's good intentions to help the environment..
- **The Value-Action Gap:** Standard Information, Education, and Communication (IEC) campaigns—like seminars and flyers—are no longer effective on their own. Residents already have high environmental awareness, but this knowledge does not translate into action when systemic barriers remain high.
- **Failure of the "Status Quo" Equal Distribution:** Currently, the limited SWM budget is divided evenly across all seven barangays. This "status quo" spreads the money so thin that it fails to fund enough enforcement or incentives to actually change behavior, causing compliance to stagnate—especially in densely populated areas like Barangay Poblacion.

Specific Policy Recommendations

To directly reduce the daily effort required to wash, sort, and store waste, we recommend the following practical interventions:

1. Provide Free or Subsidized Sorting Bins

- **The Policy:** The LGU should supply households—especially in lower-income communities like Brgy. Babalaya and Demologan—with free or heavily subsidized space-saving, color-coded bins or sacks.
- **Why it Works:** Buying multiple trash bins is viewed as an unnecessary expense by many families. Providing standard, stackable bins removes this financial barrier and solves the physical problem of storing multiple types of waste in small homes.

2. Shift Information Campaigns to Practical "How-To" Guides

- **The Policy:** Transition Information, Education, and Communication (IEC) funding away from general "save the environment" seminars. Instead, focus entirely on practical, step-by-step training.
- **Why it Works:** Telling people *why* they should segregate is less effective than showing them *how* to do it easily. Campaigns should focus on quick tips for rinsing food containers and simple ways to sort daily trash, directly reducing the physical and mental effort involved.

3. Guarantee Reliable Waste Collection Schedules

- **The Policy:** Mandate and strictly monitor a highly predictable waste collection schedule (e.g., specific days for biodegradable vs. recyclable waste).
- **Why it Works:** The longer waste sits inside a home, the bigger a nuisance it becomes due to odors, pests, and lost space. Reliable and timely collection minimizes how long households have to store their waste, directly reducing the burden on the residents.

4. Focus Resources One Barangay at a Time (Sequential Saturation)

- **The Policy:** Abandon the strategy of dividing the ₱1.5M budget equally among all barangays at once. Instead, focus the budget on one specific barangay at a time.
- **Why it Works:** By concentrating incentives and enforcement in a single area, the LGU makes the rewards of complying (and the risks of not complying) outweigh the hassle of sorting. Once a majority of that barangay builds the habit of segregating, it becomes a community norm. The LGU can then move its budget and focus to the next barangay, knowing the habit in the first area will sustain itself.

Conclusion

By making waste segregation physically easier at home and focusing the budget strategically rather than spreading it thin, the LGU of Bacolod can systematically overcome the barriers to RA 9003 compliance. This straightforward, data-driven approach maximizes the ₱1.5M budget and builds permanent, community-wide habits.